

viewers retain their sympathy for this angry, frustrated man as he desperately tries to prove himself to the world.

**See also:** *Taxi Driver* 234–39

## THE SHINING

Stanley Kubrick, 1980

Adapted from Stephen King's book of the same name, Kubrick's *The Shining* turned the author into a household name. Jack Nicholson plays the writer (and recovering alcoholic) Jack Torrance, who takes an off-season caretaker job at the Overlook Hotel in the Colorado Rockies, bringing his wife Wendy (Shelley Duvall) and young son, Danny, to stay with him in the vast, empty building. Over the weeks, Danny is haunted by increasingly horrifying visions as Jack slowly becomes homicidal, eventually chasing his family with a fire axe and the now-famous cry, "Heeere's Johnny!" Kubrick laced the movie with symbolism to produce a horror masterpiece, although King is said not to have liked it.

**See also:** *Dr. Strangelove* 176–79 ■ *2001: A Space Odyssey* 192–93

## E.T. THE EXTRA-TERRESTRIAL

Steven Spielberg, 1982

Few screen creatures have captured the hearts of the world as effectively as Spielberg's E.T., with its giant, baby eyes and the distinctive cute, rasping voice (spoken by Pat Welsh). Spielberg's direction and Melissa Mathison's script mix sentiment, sadness, and comedy in just the right proportions to keep the audience enthralled as E.T. befriends 10-year-old Elliott and then faces danger when

government agents move in. The movie is also notable for some outstanding performances by its child actors, including Henry Thomas as Elliott and Drew Barrymore as Gertie.

**See also:** *Jaws* 228–31

## SCARFACE

Brian De Palma, 1983

Violent, graphic, and over the top, Brian De Palma's remake of the 1932 Howard Hawks movie pulls no punches as it charts the rise and fall of gangster Tony Montana, played with relish by Al Pacino. Montana spirals so far out of control that he kills his sister's husband on her wedding night. The movie divided critics. Some reveled in its detailed characterization; others found it unpleasant and clichéd.

## BLOOD SIMPLE

Joel and Ethan Coen, 1984

The Coens began their directorial careers with this blood-soaked debut, a noirish thriller that features many of the themes they would revisit in later movies. A sleazy bar owner (Dan Hedaya) hires an even sleazier private detective (M. Emmet Walsh) to kill his wife (Frances McDormand). Through crossing, double-crossing, and plain incompetence, the hit goes bloodily wrong for everyone involved. Yet the Coens succeed in making the outcome absurd, funny, horrible, and inevitable. Critic Roger Ebert has remarked of the Coens' skill in plotting that "they build crazy walls with sensible bricks," and this was never more true than in *Blood Simple*.

**See also:** *Fargo* 282–83

## PARIS, TEXAS

Wim Wenders, 1984

*Paris, Texas* opens with a man (Harry Dean Stanton) wandering lost in the Texan desert, and follows his slow and painful return to his old life, as his brother drives him across the country to Los Angeles to be reacquainted with his son and wife. Playwright Sam Shepard wrote the script, producing a sensitive and understated character study that explores the nature of family and fatherhood, as the man, who starts the movie mute, gradually regains his voice and identity. Shot by Wenders's regular collaborator Robby Müller, the movie features stunning, bleak shots of the desert and of the seedy neon world of the city.

**See also:** *Wings of Desire* 258–61

## COME AND SEE

Elem Klimov, 1985

Soviet director Elem Klimov's *Come and See* is one of the few movies to show the devastation of war without a redeeming gleam of heroism. Drawing on Klimov's own boyhood trauma of fleeing the besieged city of Stalingrad during World War II, the movie follows the boy Florya, who joins the Belarusian partisans to fight the Nazis but is separated from his unit. An explosion shatters his eardrums, and from then on the movie moves through a series of ever more dire scenes, including one that shows his home village piled high with corpses. There is no redemption in the movie, or flinching, and yet Klimov finds a strange beauty in the terrible images he creates.